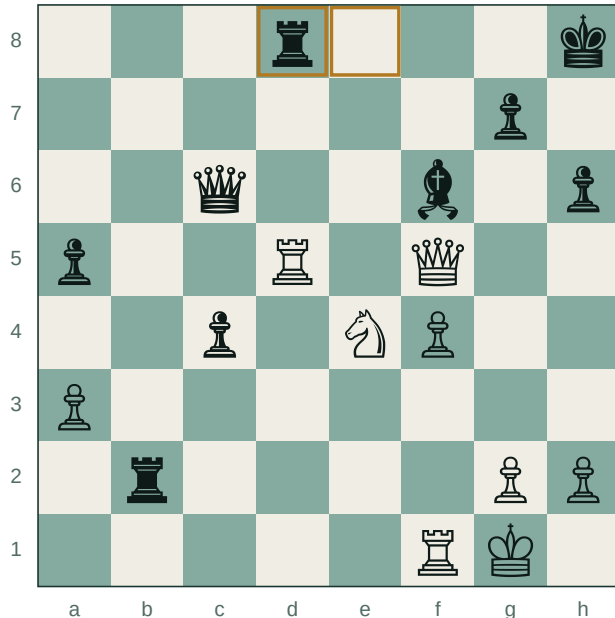


Capture the defender: White, move 35

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 34...Rd8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

35. Nxf6 Qb6+ 36. Kh1 Qxf6 37. Qxf6 gxf6 38. Rxd8+

35.Nxf6 The knight captures the bishop on f6. Recorded reply: **35...Qb6+**.

36.Kh1 The king moves from g1 to h1. Recorded reply: **36...Qxf6**.

37.Qxf6 The queen captures the queen on f6. From f6 it attacks rook on d8 and rook on b2. Recorded reply: **37...gxf6**.

38.Rxd8+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the rook on d8.

At the end, nominal material is White 14 / Black 9 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +5:** the balance goes from +0 to +5. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on h8. Geometrically undefended: queen on c6. Check for tactical protection.